

Dear Jen,

I am very sore. I have worked out three times since I discovered the gym upstairs and I am paying the price today. It's amazing how lazy your body can become in three quick months. I don't think that I even worked out that hard! Let me tell you this; I fell asleep immediately last night and slept longer than I have in a while. Today, my whole body was hurting so I had to take some Ibuprofen to make some of the soreness go away. It feels great to work out again.

Over the past few days, the TOC has undergone a transformation. People that have been working here for the last few months are getting rotated out to different positions, and new faces are arriving. Perhaps the most dramatic change is Specialist Stanton. He hates his new assignment and makes it known to everyone who will listen. I can't imagine that this attitude will get him very far. He walked in here yesterday, cursing under his breath about how he is getting screwed and how horrible it is to have to work here. I looked at him and let him carry on for about two minutes before I cooled him off. I told him that no one wants to come in here, and the TOC might not be on anyone's A-list as far as desired duty positions, but it's only fair that people rotate in and out. Unfortunately for him, it's now his turn and he will have to deal with it. He is not happy.

The Battle Captains, meanwhile, have added a third Captain to their duty roster. Captain Wilson works as the LNO to Brigade during the day and then pulls five or so hours of shift at night when nothing is going on. Captain Hamilton and Captain Nutt both say they need a break—and they are becoming increasingly frustrated with their jobs as well. Luckily for them, the addition of another person allows them to work 8 hours a day. Eight hours on, sixteen hours off. Sounds like a great deal to me. That is a recommendation that I made a long time ago—instead of dividing the day into two sections, simply split it into three, eight hour shifts. Unfortunately, the only position that has not either rotated out or been given extra personnel is mine. I still work twelve hours a day. I now split the shift with Lt. Simonson who recently returned from emergency leave in Ft. Riley.

Lt. Sproesser is now back at Alpha Company doing CA work. He has paid his dues here and is very happy to be free. I saw him yesterday and he was smiling ear to ear, and told me that he was "excited about waking up every day." Funny...I don't really remember that feeling. Lt. Kimball, Sproesser's original replacement, didn't work in the S3 shop for long. In about two days, he managed to assume Lt. Collins' old position working intelligence reports and he escaped in just 48 hours—a world record. As for myself...I am afraid that this is my lot in the army with no hope of relief. The commander even said that the TOC is the Chemical Officer's life. Great!

Oh well, I'm suckin'. We still have no timeframe for redeployment despite the Chaplain's best attempts to get more information. He even wrote to his congressman to see if he could find out when we might go home. To no avail, however, and it only